

BARTHOLOMEW. Aw, it wasn't nothin'. I only done my duty. (*Train whistle very loud and insistent.*)

THEODOSIA. Pa, get off the track, the train's coming.

AUGUSTUS. Maybe I'd better. (*He stands and breaks the strings on his wrists.*)

BARTHOLOMEW (*Bows to the audience.*) Tomorrow night we play "Ten Barrooms in a Night."

CLUMSY CURTAIN

OUT OF THE STORM

A BURLESQUE MELODRAMA

By

ARTHUR L. KASER

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OUT OF THE STORM

CAST OF CHARACTERS

(Three women, three men)

LORENZA FRIZZLEBEANan old salt.
 CLEMENTINAhis wife.
 ARRABELLAtheir daughter.
 FLORADORAthe lady in black.
 COUNT DE NICKELSa villain.
 DADZANGER DUDDLERUMPERa G-man.

CONCERNING THE CAST

LORENZA: An aged man with a squeaky voice and plenty of rheumatism. He hobbles about on a cane, but at times is very lively. He wears a comedy sailor outfit.

CLEMENTINA: An elderly lady who looks more like a spinster than a mother.

ARRABELLA: A gawky girl of eighteen, dressed in a comedy manner.

FLORADORA: Dressed in black. Wears a black veil. Speaks and acts in a very mysterious manner.

COUNT DE NICKELS: A black-mustached villain of the old-time melodrama. Dressed immaculately. Uses a monocle.

DADZANGER: He looks more like a hill-billy than a Federal officer. Very seedily dressed.

PLACE: *In a seaside cottage.*

TIME: *Late one stormy night.*

SCENE: *A very plainly furnished living room in the cottage. There is a window in Center of the rear drop or flat. Entrances Left and Right stage. Occasional flashes of lightning are seen through the window, which may be produced by a strong flashlight backstage.*

CURTAIN discovers CLEMENTINA nervously pacing the floor, wringing her hands in extreme despair and dejection.

CLEMENTINA. What a night for a storm! What a storm for a night! What a what for a which! What a—
(Clock alarm sounds offstage.) Twelve o'clock midnight, and my beloved husband not yet home! What a night for a husband! *(Lightning flash and thunder crash.)* How the world lights up. How I hope my dear, beloved husband isn't lit up— *(Enter ARRABELLA, Left, walking slowly as if she were very sad. She sits in chair near Center, but instantly leaps to her feet with a scream.)*

CLEMENTINA. My daughter, is your heart broken, too?

ARRABELLA. Far from it, Mother. I sat on a tack. Who is so senseless as to put tacks on chairs?

CLEMENTINA. 'Tis the Government, my dear. They put tax on everything. *(Lightning and thunder.)* Oh, that dreadful lightning!

ARRABELLA. But Mother, it is the only time we have electric lights. But why does not father come in his ship that is plying its way through the churning waters of the sea without?

CLEMENTINA. Without what?

ARRABELLA. Without clearance papers. Oh, Mother, Father's ship will be dashed to bits on the stern and rockbound coast, and Father cannot swim without water-wings.

CLEMENTINA. Forget not, dear Arrabella, your father is an expert wader. He used to be a wader in a lunch room. He will come, never fear.

ARRABELLA. But the papers will be lost—the documents from the Government, giving Father the option on this island whereon dwells the valuable penguins. Oh, Father, dear Father, why did you sell your peanut wagon and invest in this penguin island?

CLEMENTINA. Shush, shush, thoughtless girl, shush, shush! I repeat, shush, shush! Your father knows best what is worst. He could no longer stand the heat of the peanut roasting ovens. It was driving him nuts—peanuts, popcorn, chewing gum and—yes, Arrabella, the peanuts were getting him down. Down! Down!

ARRABELLA. And now he has an island full of penguins that will get him down—down—down. (*Loud thunder clap, followed by a masculine voice off stage yelling "Ouch!"*) Hark! Hist! Listen! Father's ship has crashed. I heard him holler ouch.

CLEMENTINA. It isn't his ship. It's his rheumatism.

ARRABELLA. His rheumatism doesn't crash. It squeaks. (*Lightning flash.*) Oh, this storm is terrible! And we, Mother, alone on this far away island. Just you and me—us—alone! (*Enter FLORADORA, Right. She goes Center, looks about in a mysterious manner, and says in a sepulchral voice, "Ah-h-h!"* (*Exits Left.*)

CLEMENTINA (*With no sign of feeling, or of surprise.*) I wonder who that lady is walking through our cottage when you and I are the only ones on this island. I wonder, I wonder, says I, thinking the same as the words spoken by me.

ARRABELLA. Mother, it is the lady of mystery.

CLEMENTINA. How know you that, Arrabella?

ARRABELLA. I saw this show before. (*Lightning flash, and thunder crash.*) Oh, Father, dear Father, come home to us now—(*Sings, improvising tune.*) The chickens are dead and we've lost the old cow.

LORENZA (*From off Right.*) Heigh-ho, and a yippy-yip-yip! Ye-ow!

CLEMENTINA. 'Tis my husband, Lorenza Frizzlebean, coming out from inna—coming in from out o' the storm. Arrabella, your father comes safely from the ship that is pounding to pieces off the coast of the Straits of Magellan, to whence we came to make our fortune raising penguins for the valuable down on their breasts that is so highly prized by furriers. End of quote.

LORENZA (*From off Right.*) Hellup me! I am in pain! I want succor!

ARRABELLA (*Yells to off Right.*) No sucker, Pa! Nothing left but gumdrops. Poor Pa! He cries with pain. What can we do? The rheumatic pains in his legs pain him painfully.

CLEMENTINA. Even so, daughter, think of his poor brothers. They were all born with wooden legs. They must ever be on the lookout for termites. Come in, my beloved husband. Come in.

LORENZA (*Stubbornly, from off stage.*) I won't come in. I won't! I won't!

ARRABELLA. He's off on another pout. Mother, did Father pay cash for this island full of penguins?

CLEMENTINA. No, my daughter. Just so much down on each bird, and if they have no down we're out o' luck. He brings with him now the papers from the Government whereby we are sole gatherers of the down on this island full of penguins on whose breasts is the down so highly prized by furriers—

ARRABELLA (*Calls to off Right.*) Come in, Father. You are interfering with the storm out there. (*Enter LORENZA, Right, limping, using a cane.*)

LORENZA (*Stops inside entrance and waves cane.*) Yippy-yip! Wow! Ye-ow! Howdy, Ma! Howdy, daughter! Howdy—(*Looks about.*) Where's grandma?

CLEMENTINA. Playing table tennis with her mother.

ARRABELLA. Oh, Father, your ship? Where is your ship?

LORENZA. I ordered it to lay to in the hen house.

CLEMENTINA. Oh, Lorenza, you did not do that! You did not put the ship in our beautiful hen house?

LORENZA. Worry not, wife. It can do no harm. I fastened down the hatchways.

CLEMENTINA. What a fowl remark.

LORENZA (*Sadly.*) I guess it isn't anything to crow about.

ARRABELLA. And the valuable papers, Pa?

LORENZA. Ha, daughter, there is a little joke connected with them 'ere papers. They was stole from me. A dark bearded man with white whiskers stole them 'ere papers while I was sipping vodka with a man.

ARRABELLA. Who was the man, Pa?

LORENZA. The black-bearded man with white whiskers. He was Count de Nickels of the Siberian Royal Order of Eradicated Czars.

CLEMENTINA. And you haven't the papers giving us the right to pick down from the penguins?

LORENZA. Worry not, Clementina. All will be well and then as soon as we pick down business will pick up. All will be well—well—Well? Won't it? I sent an S. O. S. and a G-man is coming. (*Enter FLORADORA, Left. She goes Center, says "Ah-h-!" as before and exits Right.*)

LORENZA. Hot dog! (*He hobbles toward Right.*)

CLEMENTINA. Lorenza Frizzlebean, where be ye goin'?

LORENZA. I'm a seein'-fair man, and I'm goin' to sea.

CLEMENTINA. Well, you're not goin' to see her.

LORENZA (*Returns to Center.*) When did she blow into port?

ARRABELLA. She's a mystery ship, Father.

LORENZA. Shiver me, if she ain't a trim craft. (*Lightning flash and crash.*) Hark! What was that?

ARRABELLA. Thunder.

LORENZA. Heh! I thought I recognized it as something I'd heard before. (*Enter FLORADORA, Right.*)

FLORADORA (*Stops at Center.*) Ah-h-h!

CLEMENTINA. Hussy, who are you, and if so, why?

FLORADORA. I am the Queen of the Penguins.

ARRABELLA. You look like the Queen of Spades.

FLORADORA. Years ago a ship was wrecked. I was but an infant. My father lashed me to a spar, and I was washed upon this island. I grew to womanhood among the penguins. I am now their queen. I live their life; I speak their language.

LORENZA. Auk! You can't speak penguin.

FLORADORA. Listen! I will call to them. They will answer. (*She calls to off Right.*) Wawk! Wack! Wicky-wack! (*From off Right stage there is a conglomeration of raucous bird sounds: crowing of roosters, cackling of hens, cawing of crows, turkey gobbles, etc. This is kept up until FLORADORA raises her hand for silence.*) You see, my subjects answer me.

LORENZA. Queenie, you're a wow. (*COUNT DE NICKEL's leering face appears at window. It is seen only by FLORADORA.*)

FLORADORA (*Screams.*) Eeek! That face! That mug! That pan! It is he! (*Others think she is crazy.*)

CLEMENTINA (*Indicating FLORADORA.*) She's dopey.

LORENZA. She's got penguinitis.

FLORADORA. Oh, that face! It has followed me here! It will haunt me! Oh-h—ow-oo! (*She exits Right holding her hands over her eyes.*) That face!

LORENZA. She needs watching. (*He quickly follows her.*)

CLEMENTINA. So does Pa. (*She quickly exits Right. Enter COUNT DE NICKEL, Left. ARRABELLA screams.*)

COUNT. Curses! Hist! Foiled again! Now, gal, lace up that mouth and shut up!

ARRABELLA. Who are you, Count de Nickels?

COUNT. Ah, you do not know me. I am Count de Nickels.

ARRABELLA. Then you *are* Count de Nickels?

COUNT. Yes, I am Count de Nickels.

ARRABELLA (*Aside.*) It *is* Count de Nickels.

COUNT. I am Count de Nickels, walking delegate for the Siberian Royal Order of Eradicated Czars.

ARRABELLA. No!

COUNT. Yes!

ARRABELLA. No!

COUNT. *Yes! (Yells.) Yes! (Holds out papers.)* Look! See! The Government papers! Ha-ha! I am the villain!

ARRABELLA. Father's papers!

COUNT. It is I who will pluck the down from the penguins that is so highly prized by the furriers.

ARRABELLA. No!

COUNT. Yes!

ARRABELLA. No!

COUNT (*Screams.*) *Yes!* It is I who gets the down. Third down, ten birds to go.

ARRABELLA. Villain, you shall never make a touch-down. Father will kick your goal.

COUNT. But there is a way out, gal. Marry me, my proud beauty, and your father shall get half the plumage from the penguins that is so highly prized by the furriers.

ARRABELLA. You shall be foiled, Count de Nickels. You shall be foiled in your dastardly attempt to black-face my father.

COUNT. I have left no bone unturned—no sturn unboned—no stone unturned to—

ARRABELLA. The hero will come in the nick of time.

COUNT. Never!

ARRABELLA. Oh, yes, he will, smarty. (*Takes script from table.*) Look, villain, look. On the last page it says, "Enter hero."

COUNT. Gimme that. (*He snatches the script from her, and tears off the last page.*) Now, me proud and haughty beauty, he cannot enter. I have tore up the stage directions. Ha-ha! Riches is mine! Now, me proud and haughty Arrabella Frizzlebean, marry me, or become my grandmother!

ARRABELLA. Never! Only over my dead body which lies yonder in yonder graveyard will I marry you, Count de Nickels, of the Siberian Royal Order of Eradicated Czars! Neither shall you pluck the plumage from the penguins that is so highly prized by the furriers!

COUNT (*Suddenly grasps ARRABELLA'S wrists and hisses.*) You are in my power!

ARRABELLA (*Struggles.*) Release me, villain! This isn't a power house.

COUNT. Ha-ha, me proud damsel, I am going to kiss you!

ARRABELLA. No!

COUNT. Yes!

ARRABELLA. No!

COUNT (*Yells.*) *Yes!* (*They struggle, and as they sway back and forth, ARRABELLA succeeds in extracting the papers from COUNT'S pocket. She tosses them to side of stage. He is not aware that she has procured the papers. He overpowers her and is about to kiss her. Enter CLEMENTINA, Right.*)

CLEMENTINA (*Sharply.*) Arrabella, leave that poor guy go at once. (*Enter LORENZA, Right.*)

LORENZA. Hold! Stop! Halt! Cease! Desist! Unhand my daughter—Ye gods! 'Tis the black-bearded man with long white whiskers with whom I sipped vodka, and who stole the papers entitling me to pick down from the penguins that is so highly prized by the furriers.

COUNT (*Steps back.*) Curses! Tin-foiled again, and riches within my reach. Ha-ha! But I still have the valuable papers. (*He reaches in pocket for the papers and discovers they are gone.*) Gone! The papers are gone!

Old man, you shall pay dearly for this low-down trick. *(He draws an enormous revolver from pocket. Off stage there is simulated bang-bang of many guns.)* Curses! the Texas Rangers! *(Enter DADZANGER Right, with slingshot which he aims at COUNT.)*

DADZANGER. Hands up!

COUNT. Curses! Dadzanger Duddlerumper, the G-man! *(Raises hands. Enter FLORADORA, Right.)*

FLORADORA. Ah-h-h-h!

COUNT *(Gasps.)* Floradora, you here? How you have grown.

FLORADORA. Yes, Count de Nickels, of the Siberian Royal Order of Eradicated Czars, it is I, Floradora. I am now among friends, and never again do I want to set eyes upon such as you. These honest people shall pluck the down from the penguins that is so highly prized by the furriers.

DADZANGER *(Picks up the papers.)* Leave it to a G-man to recover the valuable papers.

ARRABELLA. We have regained our happiness because of this brave G-man. *(She places her arms about DADZANGER'S neck.)* Father, I love this man.

LORENZA *(To DADZANGER.)* Take her, my boy, and bless you, children.

CLEMENTINA. At last all is peaceful and serene. *(Instantly, off stage there is again that conglomeration of fowl sounds, but much louder than before. The lightning flashes and the thunder roars. Those on stage place hands over ears.)*

CURTAIN

(LORENZA may be outside of the curtain line when the curtain descends, and then, discovering where he is, LORENZA may make a dash to get off stage.)

THE STOLEN SUBMARINE

Or
WHO DONE IT?

A PARODY ON THE OLD MELODRAMA

By
ARTHUR L. KASER

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